Outlook desktop cannot send or receive mail

SAH-M365-001 | Version 1.0 | Category: microsoft_365 | 14 October 2026

SYNTHETIC DEMO CONTENT - not approved company policy. Employee checks only. No autonomous system changes.

APPLIES TO

Sample Microsoft 365 work-account scenario. The employee has an existing Outlook setup. Do not use this article to configure a new mailbox or recover an account.

CLARIFY FIRST

Ask whether sending, receiving or both are affected; identify Outlook desktop versus browser; record the visible error and whether general web browsing works. Do not collect message contents.

EMPLOYEE CHECKS

1. Check whether the employee can open a familiar permitted website. If not, use the network guide.
2. If internet access works, ask whether they can open their existing approved work-webmail bookmark. Do not invent a company login address.
3. If webmail works, record that desktop Outlook is affected and offer webmail as a temporary workaround.
4. If webmail also fails, record the error and hand off for account/service investigation.

STOP AND HAND OFF

An engineer must investigate persistent desktop failures. Do not delete profiles or mail files, remove accounts, change server settings or resend queued messages repeatedly. Never request a password or MFA code.

COMPLETION EVIDENCE

Working webmail is a workaround, not proof that desktop Outlook is fixed. Keep the original problem unresolved until the employee explicitly confirms it is resolved; otherwise hand off with the workaround noted.

TECHNICAL REFERENCE

Microsoft Support: I cannot send or receive messages in Outlook.
https://support.microsoft.com/en-us/outlook/i-can-t-send-or-receive-messages-in-outlook